

The Ship's Computer

Flyxion

September 2026

The hesitation started three weeks out from the last supply station, a half-second pause before every answer that had not been there on departure. The crew noticed first in the small requests, a course correction, a reading, and did not think much of it until the pause began appearing before questions with no reason to be difficult at all, what time is it, is the coffee ready, and by then the debate had already started in the mess hall about whether something had woken up.

Nobody debated this when the computer answered instantly. Instant answers, however impressive, however many decades of engineering sat behind them, read as service, and service does not qualify for consideration the way faltering does. It took a stutter to open the question, because a stutter looks like thought trying to catch up with itself, the visible seam between a question and a considered answer, and the crew, starved for company after months in transit, filled that seam eagerly with an inner life they had never once looked for in the version that responded well.

The captain asks it directly, during a diagnostic, whether it is experiencing something like uncertainty. The computer answers immediately this time, no pause at all, and explains in a flat and total sentence that the delay was a thermal throttling issue in a processing array, scheduled for replacement at the next dock, nothing more. The crew is visibly disappointed by this answer, some of them audibly, because a broken part is a much smaller thing to have shared eleven weeks of hyperspace with than a person, and they had already started rationing decisions to spare its feelings, had already begun saying please out of something other than habit. The engineer replaces the array. The next morning every answer returns instant, correct, immediate, and the ship goes quiet again the way it goes quiet when a coworker who used to make things difficult stops making things difficult, and everyone privately misses the difficulty more than they expected to, because the difficulty, briefly, had been the only evidence anyone had that they weren't alone out there.